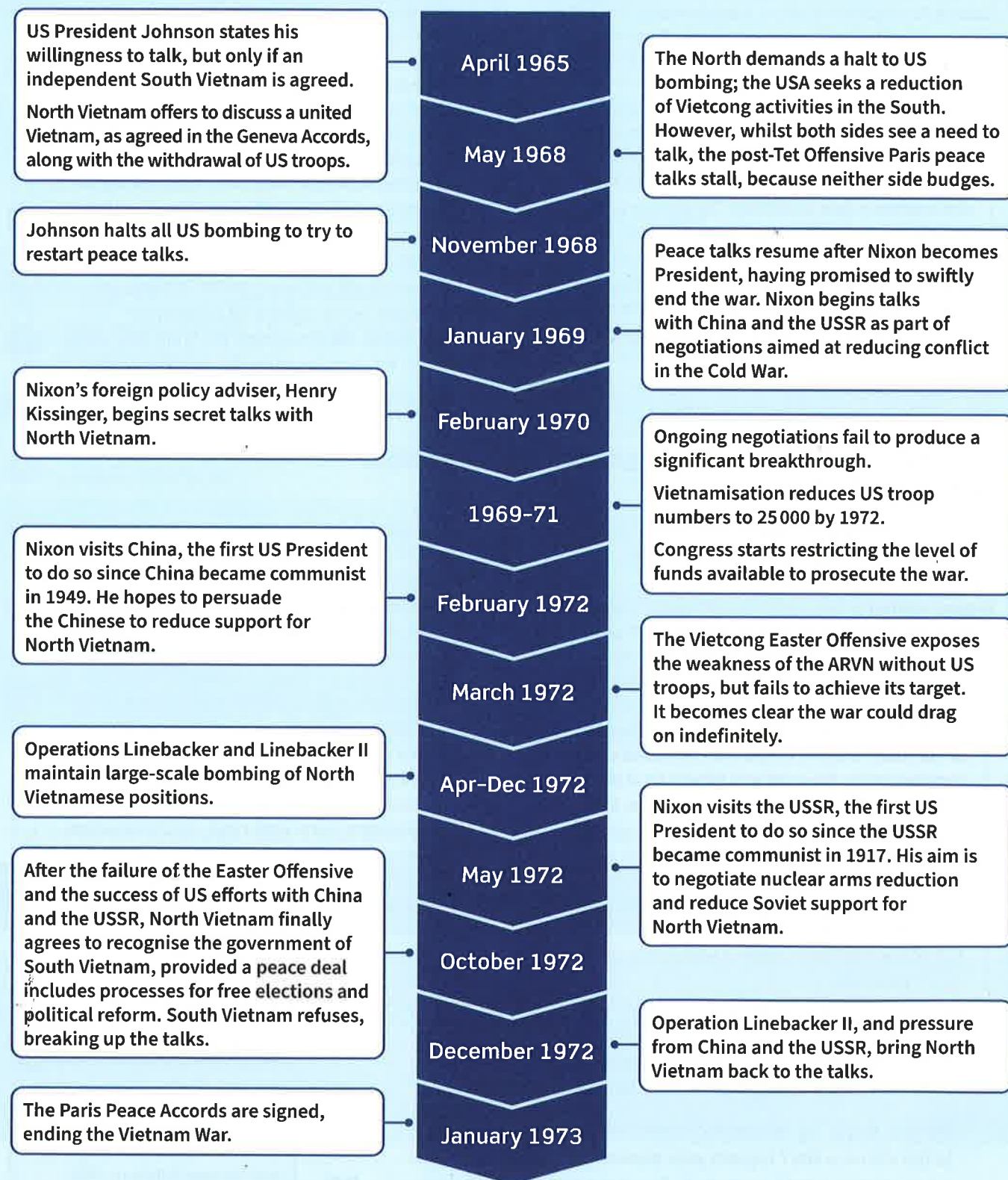


11 The peace process and the end of the Vietnam War

Reasons for and features of the peace negotiations, 1965-73

There were various reasons why the USA decided to negotiate for peace in Vietnam. These included the consequences of the Tet Offensive, the problems of pursuing the conflict at home and in Vietnam, and a desire for peace.



The significance of the Paris Peace Accords, 1973

The Paris Peace Accords allowed the USA to withdraw from Vietnam without admitting defeat, but in Vietnam itself it was never more than a pause in the conflict.

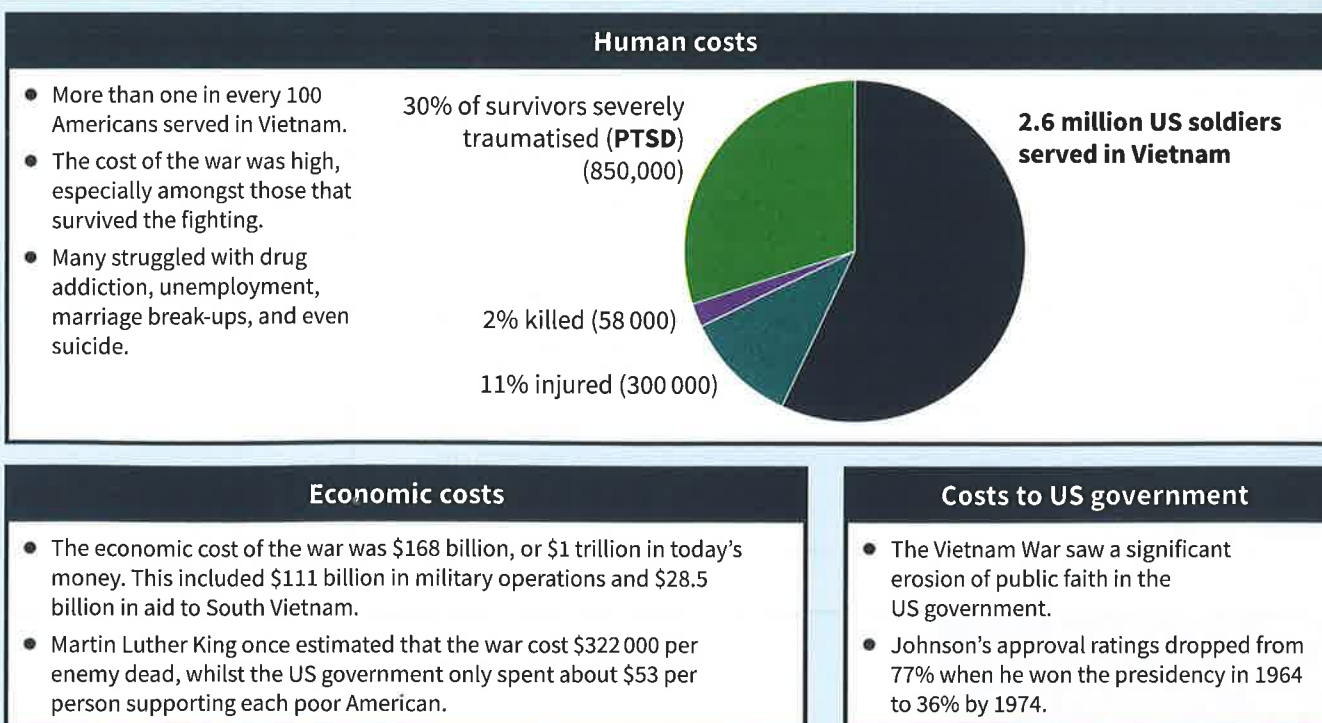
Terms of the Paris Peace Accords

- ✓ Withdrawal of all US and allied forces within 60 days.
- ✓ Ceasefire in South Vietnam following the divisions of the 1954 Geneva Agreements.
- ✓ Reunification of Vietnam through peaceful means without invasion by either country, and without foreign interference.
- ✓ Withdrawal of foreign troops from Laos and Cambodia.
- ✓ Financial contributions from the USA to 'heal the wounds of war' throughout Indochina.

What happened

- US troops were withdrawn.
- The ceasefire lasted only until December 1974, when North Vietnam invaded the South.
- The capital of South Vietnam, Saigon, finally fell in April 1975.
- The collapse of the South's economy after the US withdrawal meant that the communists were mostly welcomed. Vietnam was united on 2 July 1976 to form the communist Socialist Republic of Vietnam.
- US troops were withdrawn, but Vietnam invaded Cambodia in 1978.
- A figure of \$3.25 billion was discussed, but no money was ever received, partly because of the failure of both sides to uphold other parts of the peace agreement.

The economic and human costs of the war for the USA



11 The peace process and the end of the Vietnam War

Reasons for the failure of the USA in Vietnam

North Vietnamese strengths

The USA lost face abroad over Vietnam. By 1975, the whole of Vietnam was communist, whilst the USA was a divided nation. But why did the USA – a global superpower – lose?

The US defeat was the result of both North Vietnamese strengths and US weaknesses.



North Vietnamese strengths	
The Ho Chi Minh Trail allowed guerrilla groups in the South to be resupplied throughout the war. The USA could not destroy the trail because it went through Laos and Cambodia.	✓
The USSR and China supported North Vietnam with money, military aid, and, in the case of China, over 300 000 troops. The aid often included sophisticated modern weaponry to bridge the gap with their opponents.	✓
The Vietcong soldiers spoke the same language as the South Vietnamese and shared their culture, which helped them persuade many South Vietnamese to assist them. They were also familiar with the land.	✓
North Vietnamese General Giap was a highly effective general and organiser, who understood how to inspire troops and keep them supplied. He employed the same tactics that he had used to defeat the French.	✓
Members of the US-supported South Vietnamese government were seen as imperialist puppets . By contrast, Ho Chi Minh (who died in 1969) and General Giap were seen as Vietnamese heroes who had fought the French and the Japanese.	✓
The USA had to avoid provoking the USSR and China for fear that it might lead to nuclear war. China had developed its own nuclear bombs by 1967.	✓
Guerrilla tactics were very effective in undermining US morale and counteracting the superior numbers and technological advantages of the USA and ARVN.	✓
Communism and the prospect of a fair share of land had significant appeal to poor Vietnamese peasants.	✓
Vietcong troops were highly committed and engaged with the cause, in contrast to many of the US soldiers, who struggled to understand why they were even in Vietnam. Many Vietnamese troops had experience from fighting the French.	✓
The Vietcong were willing to sustain more losses than the USA. US General Westmoreland once remarked that any US General that suffered Giap's losses would have been sacked instantly.	✓
The Vietnamese cause appealed to anti-government protesters in the USA. It was portrayed as a David v. Goliath struggle of Eastern resistance to Western imperialist aggression.	✓



Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

PTSD imperialist puppet psychedelic



US weaknesses

The North Vietnamese understood and exploited the weaknesses in the US military.



US weaknesses	
The USA struggled with fighting a jungle war, failing to adapt to the harsh conditions. Much of Vietnam was covered with jungle, which was difficult for troops and equipment to get through, and the weather was humid and rainy.	✗
The USA never got to grips with fighting a guerrilla war, which neutralised its technological advantages. The fear of Vietcong booby traps was significant.	✗
US troops were young and inexperienced (the average age of combat troops killed in action was 22).	✗
Many of the drafted soldiers did not want to fight. Morale was low both in Vietnam and at home.	✗
Drugs were available in Vietnam. A 1971 report by the Department of Defense said that 51% of US troops had smoked marijuana, 31% had taken psychedelics , and 28% had used hard drugs, such as heroin.	✗
Drafted troops could return to the USA after a year, so the army lost soldiers as they gained experience.	✗
US troops failed to win over the 'hearts and minds' of the South Vietnamese, either to the benefits of capitalism or to South Vietnam's leaders, who were seen as puppets of the US government.	✗
Bombing raids and chemical weapons, as well as the treatment of Vietnamese civilians by the US army, both in general and in extreme cases like at My Lai, further alienated Vietnamese support and made the USA look bad globally.	✗
Vietnamisation failed badly. The ARVN were neither committed nor well-trained enough to hold off the Vietcong without US support.	✗
The perception of the US war effort was seen not as an attempt to contain communism, but as a continuation of French and Japanese imperialism.	✗
The war became increasingly unpopular in the USA. Media and public opinion turned against the war after 1968, making it hard to justify further investment.	✗
The cost of the war was a huge burden on the US economy, leading to spending cuts at home, increased taxes, and inflation.	✗



The impact of opposition to the war in the USA

- Vietnam was the first conflict to be viewed widely from people's living rooms. What was broadcast shamed many Americans and led to increasing distrust of the government.
- Public protests and criticism of the US government grew throughout the 1960s. As opposition to the war mounted, that became harder for the government to ignore. Elected officials could not remain in post for long without popular support.
- Unlike those returning in 1945, at the end of the Second World War, many Vietnam War veterans faced hostility and abuse, as well as discrimination in the workplace, highlighting the deep divisions within US society.

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

1	What were the main demands of the two sides when peace talks began in Paris in 1968?	Put paper here	The North demanded a halt to all US bombing; the USA wanted a reduction of Vietcong activities in the South
2	When was the Paris Peace Accords signed?	Put paper here	January 1973
3	How long did the Paris Peace Accords give the USA to remove their troops from Vietnam?	Put paper here	60 days
4	When did the communist North formally reunite the country?	Put paper here	2 July 1976
5	How much did the Vietnam War cost the USA?	Put paper here	\$168 billion, or \$1 trillion in today's money
6	What percentage of the US population served in Vietnam?	Put paper here	More than 1% (one in every 100)
7	What percentage of the surviving soldiers experienced PTSD?	Put paper here	30%
8	Who was the main leader of the North Vietnamese military forces during the war?	Put paper here	General Giap
9	Why did communism appeal to some of the South Vietnamese?	Put paper here	The prospect of land redistribution and the association with national heroes such as Ho Chi Minh and Giap
10	Why did geographical conditions make it difficult for US troops in Vietnam?	Put paper here	Much of the country was covered with jungle that was difficult for troops and equipment to get through; the weather was humid and rainy
11	What problems did returning Vietnam veterans face when back in the USA?	Put paper here	Psychological problems including PTSD; drug addiction; unemployment; marriage break-up; suicide; hostility and abuse as veterans, including discrimination in the workplace

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

1	Which campaigns did King plan in 1966 and 1967, and which cities did they focus on?	Put paper here	1966: the Chicago Freedom Movement, Chicago; 1967: the Poor People's Campaign, Washington, D.C.
2	What happened to US casualties in Vietnam in the years after Vietnamisation began?	Put paper here	They dropped significantly, from 11 600 in 1969 to just over 2000 in 1971
3	What happened at Kent State University in 1970 that increased opposition to the war?	Put paper here	Four students were shot dead by state troopers during a protest against the Cambodia invasion

Practice

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: US sailors and support staff pushing a helicopter off a US ship in the South China Sea to make room for incoming flights filled with evacuees fleeing the Vietcong during the fall of Saigon in 1975.



SOURCE TIP

What sorts of inferences might you draw from a source like this? Ask yourself the following questions:

- What are the people doing and why are they doing it?
- Do they look organised or panicked?
- What might be the cost of their actions?
- Do most of the people look like citizens or military?
- What does the caption tell you? How can that help?

- 1 Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about the end of the war in Vietnam. (4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

(i) What I can infer:	
Details in the source that tell me this:	
(ii) What I can infer:	
Details in the source that tell me this:	

- 2 Explain why the North Vietnamese won the Vietnam War. (12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- the landscape and climate of Vietnam
- the tactics of the Vietcong

You **must** also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

Revisit the different causal factors: social, economic, political, cultural, and military. Can you list why North Vietnam won, linked to each factor? What would be a good third reason to choose here?

